

WHAT YOU NEED TO KNOW: LASTING COMMUNITY BENEFITS

Background

Round 2 of The Extreme Heat and Community Resilience Program will fund Early and Advanced Infrastructure projects to mitigate the impacts of extreme heat. Project proposals for Round 2 must demonstrate how they advance the Extreme Heat Program Values of Harm Reduction, Collaborative Partnerships, Belonging, and Lasting Community Benefits.

Understanding Lasting Community Benefits as a Program Value

Competitive projects that result in lasting community benefits recognize that addressing extreme heat requires investments that extend beyond individual projects, contributing to the long-term resilience and well-being of communities vulnerable to extreme heat. Through activities, lessons learned, and relationships generated during the grant term, projects should build momentum for additional investment. By cultivating community interest and political support, projects can leverage additional resources to scale infrastructure solutions and broaden their long-term benefits.

To ensure lasting community benefits, EHCRP Round 2 requires the production of a heat-related Planning Document for Early Infrastructure projects or the production of a Future Implementation Playbook for Advanced Infrastructure projects. **These documents are intended to be a central part of the project rather than an afterthought – competitive applications will detail plans for the production of the appropriate document and explain how and why this will create lasting community benefits.**

What do Lasting Community Benefits look like in a project?

Projects that provide lasting community benefits create broader, long-term resources that extend beyond a single solution. Effective project design should drive lasting change by influencing policy, launching new programs, creating thoughtful planning for the future, and catalyzing future infrastructure investments. Consider the following questions to incorporate lasting community benefits into your project design:

- How does my project set my community up for future heat mitigation projects?
- How will this project shift current practices, systems, or decisions—not just address an immediate need?
- Does my project create opportunities for future engagement around heat mitigation or build a coalition of engaged community members?
- How will the project generate data, evidence, or infrastructure that can influence policy or programmatic decisions?
- Does the project pilot a new model, methods, or approach that could be scaled or replicated?
- What mechanisms will ensure the work continues or expands after the grant period?
- By implementing this project, what changes around extreme heat in your community do you envision in 5 years? 10 years?

Types of Lasting Community Benefits

A community can experience lasting benefits in many different ways, and a project with a wide variety of lasting benefits will be considered stronger than a project with few lasting benefits. The table below provides an overview of the types of strategies that can be used to ensure lasting benefits and examples of activities that enable resource longevity.

Note that many of these examples are future-oriented, not infrastructure based, and/or based in creating or updating a plan. Your required Planning Document (for Early Infrastructure grantees) or Future Implementation Playbook (for Advanced Infrastructure grantees) will provide a strategy for future investment and Lasting Community Benefits. Make sure that your Full Application clearly establishes the ways in which your Planning Document or Future Implementation Playbook will contribute to Lasting Community Benefits outside of or in addition to the accompanying infrastructure implemented.

Lasting Strategy	Examples
Policy Change	• Adoption of heat-resilient building codes (e.g., cool roofs, reflective pavements) • Updates to zoning codes to require heat-mitigating shade structures or minimum tree canopy standards • Ordinances establishing heat emergency response protocols
Thoughtful Planning	• Integrating heat mitigation strategies into citywide plans and critical infrastructure strategies in parks, streets, and housing • Updating parks or transportation master plans to prioritize shaded corridors • Developing a community-wide extreme heat adaptation plan that identifies priority infrastructure
New Programs	• Launching a neighborhood cooling center network • Creating a home weatherization and heat mitigation program (cool roofs, insulation, shading) • Establishing a heat health-alert program that combines outreach, wellness checks, and real-time heat risk communication
Effective Infrastructure	• Installing cooling infrastructure (e.g., chillers, cool pavements, shade structures) that can be scaled and replicated • Deploying smart heat sensors to monitor temperatures and inform heat-response operations over time

Prompts to consider

Although the following questions are not included in the Full Application, considering them during application development can help you to understand and plan for Lasting Community Benefits throughout the application and planning processes.

- What systems, partnerships, or governance structures are we establishing now that will support long-term, community-driven heat mitigation?
- Have we engaged community members in order to determine what types of long-term care and ownership the community is willing and able to take over the project, including after the end of the grant term?
- How can this project expand community capacity (e.g., training, local hiring, stewardship models)?
- How are we designing and building the infrastructure to enable its long-term use?
- How can the project's design reduce maintenance burdens or create new maintenance partnerships so the benefit can last?
- Does the design integrate policy, land use, or regulatory shifts that support sustained heat mitigation?
- How will the Planning Document or Future Implementation Playbook clearly and concisely reflect these elements and provide recommendations for future projects?
- What are mechanisms for institutionalizing lessons learned (e.g., adopting new standards, updating plans, influencing codes, etc.)?
- How will the project's monitoring and evaluation results be used to refine future heat strategies or policies, and how can we best communicate these findings through the reporting and peer learning grant requirements?

Where and how to include Lasting Community Benefits in the Full Application

Lasting Community Benefits should be emphasized throughout both the Full Application and the project process. For a competitive application, integrate Lasting Community Benefits in the following application areas:

- **Project overview narrative:** Ensure that this narrative explains how your project plans for the longevity of implemented infrastructure and contributes to lasting change.
- **Lasting Community Benefits question:** This section is the best place to talk about your project's Lasting Community Benefits in detail. Elements of this may include infrastructure longevity, plans for continued maintenance, plans for continued community engagement, an explanation of how this project will support or lead to future heat mitigation efforts, information on future plans for strengthening partnerships, and more. Tip: be as thorough as possible, and be sure to discuss what metrics you will use to evaluate and report lasting benefits.
- **Project workplan and budget:** In the budget and workplan, development of your Planning Document or Future Implementation Playbook will occur in Task 5: Planning and Policy. Include details in your workplan and budget that show how your project infrastructure and engagement activities will inform the final deliverable.

Evaluating Lasting Community Benefits

One optional exercise to help you develop a clear framework for lasting community benefits and to establish a narrative for your application is to think about what metrics you would use to measure and evaluate benefits over time. Developing clear metrics to track the performance, outcomes, and community impact of the proposed infrastructure demonstrates project efficacy and helps to determine whether the project benefits have longevity. To get started:

1. Envision the long-term outcomes that your project will achieve,
2. Translate your outcomes into measurable indicators, and
3. Create a plan that describes how metrics will be tracked, by whom, and when.

Metrics should align with your project goals and help identify if your project is on track to meet those intended goals. Metrics should also be feasible to measure, collect, and track over time; this is essential to establishing lasting community benefit. Use the table below to help you think about broad categories of potential metrics.

Category	Sample Metrics
Heat Impact and Mitigation	• % increase in canopy cover in target zones • Estimated °F reduction in surface temps • Hours of usable shade added per day • Reported reduction in heat-related stress or symptoms
Belonging and Community Benefits	• Total population reached • Reduced exposure for impacted groups (e.g., outdoor workers, seniors) • Community satisfaction or perceived safety/comfort • Number of people engaged in planning or education • Number of people attending more than one program, training, event
Implementation and Performance	• Number of trees planted, cool roofs installed, shade structures built, etc. • Tree survival rate at 1 and 3 years • Sq. ft. of reflective pavement or green infrastructure
Systemic Change	• Policies created or updated • Partnerships established • Datasets created (e.g., local heat vulnerability index) • Number of departments integrating heat into planning practices • Increased maintenance capacity or staffing